



Inspection Report

Mystic Misfits
9515 FM 1255
Grand Saline, TX 75140

Customer ID: **6016637**
Certificate: **74-C-1155**
Site: 001
Mystic Misfits

Type: FOCUSED INSPECTION
Date: 02-MAY-2026

2.1(b)(2)(ii)

Requirements and application

The licensee is exhibiting two bears without being licensed to do so. During the March 23, 2026, licensing inspection, the facility had no bears on site and lacked a suitable enclosure for housing bears, and, as such, APHIS did not license the facility for bears. Without authorization, the facility has acquired and is exhibiting two bears in an enclosure that remains incomplete and the animals are confined to a small yard attached to a modified shipping container.

Licenses authorize a specific number and specific type of animals to ensure that licensees have appropriate facilities and staff to meet the required care and husbandry standards.

A licensee must obtain a new license before using any animal beyond those types or numbers authorized under the existing license.

To be corrected before exhibition of unauthorized animals can occur.

2.131(c)(1) **Direct** **Repeat**

Handling of animals.

During public exhibitions, the facility fails to handle nonhuman primates in a manner that minimizes the risk of harm to the animals and the public. For example, in the encounter involving a capuchin (Theo), inspectors observed a mother, who was a member of the public, forcing Theo to engage with her son. During this encounter, Theo used his limbs to push away from the child and the mother continued to apply Theo to her son's body. As Theo worked to escape being handled, he had his mouth wide open near the child's forehead and face as he moved down the child's body, and then bit the child on the arm. The mother said, "maybe not" and released the monkey, who ran away. This same mother and son, both wearing blue shirts, were observed handling Theo roughly while trying to pick him up. Inspectors also observed these individuals chasing Theo as he tried to get away.

Inspectors also observed Theo jumping unpredictably from one member of the public to another, landing on their heads, shoulders, or backs without warning. Members of the public repeatedly grabbed and passed Theo from person to person as he squirmed, frequently having to readjust their hold on Theo or lower themselves toward the ground to prevent Theo from falling from chest height or higher.

Prepared By: AMY JIRSA-SMITH
USDA, APHIS, Animal Care
Title: ANIMAL CARE INSPECTOR

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Additionally, inspectors observed several instances of Theo biting and nipping at members of the public.

- A blonde-haired boy wearing a black and yellow shirt was bitten on the ear by Theo. The child began crying and trying to pull away. Several minutes later, as the capuchin lunged toward the boy's face, the boy's mother said, "he's trying to say he is sorry." She then asked the man holding the crying boy, "he bit him again?" The man shook his head no, while another member of the public pulled the capuchin back into her lap.
- A girl wearing a pink sweatshirt was bitten on the ear by Theo. Inspectors observed the incident, hearing her say, "he just bit me," while rubbing her ear. Afterward, she pulled up her hood to prevent further contact.
- Inspectors observed several additional incidents, most involving small children, with Theo biting the children's ears and/or necks.

Inspectors observed that the facility failed to implement measures to minimize risks to the animals and the public associated with contact between humans and nonhuman primates, including injuries from bites and the transmission of zoonotic diseases. Members of the public who exhibited signs of illness, such as coughing and a runny nose, were seen interacting with Theo and Buddha.

Failure to handle animals in a manner that minimizes risk can result in injury or be harmful to the health and well-being of the animal or the public.

During public exhibition, any animal must be handled so there is minimal risk of harm to the animal and to the public, with sufficient distance and/or barriers between the animals and the general public so as to assure the safety of animals and the public.

2.131(c)(3) Direct

Handling of animals.

The facility exposes young or immature animals to rough public handling that is detrimental to their health and well being. The facility allows members of the public to enter the primary enclosures of a young spider monkey, Buddha. Inspectors observed members of the public handling the animals roughly, including chasing Buddha inside the enclosure and grabbing the animal by the arms, jerking him up off the ground. Inspectors also observed Buddha climbing the side of his enclosure to avoid children who were chasing him and attempting to touch and grab the spider monkey. The attendant was positioned approximately 8-10 feet away from the public-animal interactions and, at times, had his back turned while conversing with other members of the public, failing to provide the required observation and supervision of the young monkeys and members of the public.

Approximately an hour to an hour and a half into the four hour event, inspectors observed Buddha climbing up the sides of the enclosure in an apparent attempt to move away from the public.

Exposure to rough handling or extended periods of exhibition can cause young animals to become stressed impacting their health.

Young or immature animals shall not be exposed to rough or excessive public handling or exhibited for periods of time which would be detrimental to their health or well-being.

To be corrected from May 3, 2026 forward.

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2.131(d)(2)

Handling of animals.

A responsible, knowledgeable, and readily identifiable employee or attendant was not present at all times during periods of public contact.

On April 10, 2026, APHIS officials observed several instances in which members of the public were interacting with the animals without any attendant present, as well as instances where attendants were performing other duties away from the areas of public contact and, as a result, the attendants were unable to intervene to ensure the safety of the animals or the public.

APHIS officials observed the public in physical contact with animals when no attendant was present to intervene, if necessary, as follows:

- APHIS officials observed the coati housed in an enclosure just inside the facility entrance reaching out and touching members of the public, while the public scratched the coati's back through the fencing.
- APHIS officials observed members of the public reaching through the fence of the tapir's primary enclosure to scratch the animal's nose, and pet and feed the animal.
- In the petting zoo enclosure, inspectors observed members of the public petting and feeding the animals, which included two eland, an oryx, several goats, and a kunekune pig.

A responsible, knowledgeable, and readily identifiable employee or attendant must be present at all times during periods of public contact.

On May 2, 2026, inspectors observed the tapir exhibition area, the emu and ostrich area, the young nonhuman primate area, and the lemur encounter area, all of which allowed direct public contact with the animals. During these encounters, attendants were not readily identifiable or were performing other duties that prevented them from monitoring the areas where public interactions were occurring.

The facility actively encourages public interactions with the animals by providing food at entry that can be fed to all the animals except "the meat eaters." However, attendants were not stationed throughout the facility, and were not readily identifiable, to monitor these interactions. The following areas had no attendants present during public interactions, as observed by inspectors:

- At the tapir feeding area, multiple members of the public were feeding sweet potatoes over the enclosure fence line directly into the tapir's mouth.
- At the emu and ostrich feeding area, members of the public were feeding the emu while the bird had its head and neck through the fence.

In the following areas, inspectors observed the attendants performing other duties and not actively monitoring public interactions:

- During lemur encounters, inspectors observed the attendant allowing members of the public into the enclosure while he remained in the lockout area outside the enclosure. The attendant's location did not allow him to intervene during interactions, as necessary, when lemurs were moving on the heads and shoulders of members of the public.
- During the "baby encounters," inspectors observed a white-faced capuchin jumping on peoples' heads and shoulders. Inspectors also observed a mother and son chasing the white-faced capuchin and, while the animal was trying to get away, the capuchin bit the son as the mother attempted to hold the capuchin like a baby.
- In the entrance building, several members of the public were holding and passing around two ferrets while the attendant

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was behind the counter tending to other guests. Inspectors observed members of the public removing the ferrets from their enclosure, carrying the ferrets around the room and returning them to their enclosure without an attendant's assistance.

The facility must ensure that there is a responsible, knowledgeable, and readily identifiable employee or attendant present at all times during periods of public contact.

To be corrected from May 3, 2026 forward.

3.78(e) Direct

Outdoor housing facilities.

The facility allows public contact with nonhuman primates without ensuring the animals are trained or under the direct control of a knowledgeable and experienced handler.

On April 10, 2026, the facility allowed public encounters with a group of lemurs and two monkeys (Theo and Buddha). During the lemur encounter, APHIS officials observed the lemurs crawling on the door and soliciting attention as members of the public prepared to enter the enclosure. The facility employee supervising the encounter stated that she had been on the job for approximately one month and had no animal training or experience. She also stated that the lemurs were untrained and could not be recalled if necessary. In addition, she reported that there was no limit on the number of people allowed in the enclosure at one time, explaining that the encounter accommodated "as many as can fit in here," and that on some evenings the enclosure is full of people.

During the interactions with the lemurs and monkeys, APHIS officials observed the nonhuman primates climbing on the arms, shoulders, heads, and backs of members of the public. During one interaction involving a woman and a young man, a capuchin, Theo, jumped onto the woman, causing her to loudly vocalize in surprise. The employee did not have direct control of the animal, had to pull it off the woman, and struggled to maintain a hold on the primate for the remainder of the encounter.

On May 2, 2026, inspectors observed members of the public entering the lemurs' primary enclosure and having physical contact with the animals. The facility's employee remained in the lockout area, separated from both the public and the lemurs. A facility employee told inspectors that the lemurs were untrained. The inspectors observed lemurs jumping on the heads, shoulders, and backs of members of the public. Since the facility employee was physically separated from the animals and the public, this did not demonstrate direct control over the lemurs as they moved freely within the enclosure and jumped on members of the public. This separation, combined with the lack of direct control, demonstrates that the employee lacks adequate experience and knowledge related to handling lemurs.

Inspectors also observed public contact with a young spider monkey, Buddha, and a capuchin monkey, Theo. These animals were untrained, and the facility employee—seated on one side of the enclosure near the entrance to the enclosure for most of the encounter—did not have direct control of either monkey. The monkeys freely climbed on and bit members of the public, while the employee told visitors the animals were just "playing." Inspectors observed the facility employee visiting with guests near the entrance, while making no attempt to control the interactions or intervene to ensure the safety of the animals or the public.

The lack of training and control was further demonstrated when Theo took Chapstick from a visitor. The employee chased the animal around the enclosure shouting "drop it, drop it, Theo drop it" but the animal did not respond and continued to run. A member of the public ultimately intervened and retrieved the Chapstick.

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The employee's decision to remain seated near the enclosure entrance during public interactions, combined with the lack of direct control over the animals, demonstrates inadequate experience and knowledge related to handling these primates.

The licensee must ensure that any nonhuman primates used in uncaged public exhibits are trained and under the direct control and supervision of an experienced handler or trainer at all times when the public is present.

To be corrected from May 3, 2026 forward.

This inspection and exit interview were conducted with the licensees.

Additional Inspectors:

Louis Divincenti

Patricia Laracuente, VETERINARY MEDICAL OFFICER

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Species Inspected

Cust No	Cert No	Site	Site Name	Inspection
6016637	74-C-1155	001	Mystic Misfits	02-MAY-2026

Count	Scientific Name	Common Name
000001	<i>Cebus capucinus</i>	WHITE-HEADED / WHITE-THROATED CAPUCHIN
000001	<i>Ateles geoffroyi</i>	BLACK-HANDED SPIDER MONKEY
000001	<i>Eulemur fulvus</i>	BROWN LEMUR
000002	<i>Varecia rubra</i>	RED RUFFED LEMUR
000002	<i>Varecia variegata</i>	BLACK-AND-WHITE RUFFED LEMUR
000002	<i>Aonyx cinereus</i>	ORIENTAL SMALL-CLAWED OTTER
000001	<i>Tapirus terrestris</i>	SOUTH AMERICAN TAPIR
000001	<i>Nasua olivacea</i>	MOUNTAIN COATI
000002	<i>Mustela putorius furo</i>	DOMESTIC FERRET
000002	<i>Sus scrofa domestica</i>	DOMESTIC PIG / POTBELLY PIG / MICRO PIG
000001	<i>Oryx leucoryx</i>	ARABIAN ORYX
000002	<i>Taurotragus oryx</i>	COMMON ELAND
000002	<i>Dromaius novaehollandiae</i>	EMU
000004	<i>Capra hircus</i>	DOMESTIC GOAT
000001	<i>Struthio camelus</i>	COMMON OSTRICH
000001	<i>Ammotragus lervia</i>	BARBARY SHEEP
000001	<i>Ovis aries aries</i>	SHEEP INCLUDING ALL DOMESTIC BREEDS
000006	<i>Cervus elaphus</i>	RED DEER
000002	<i>Ursus arctos</i>	BROWN BEAR
000035	Total	